

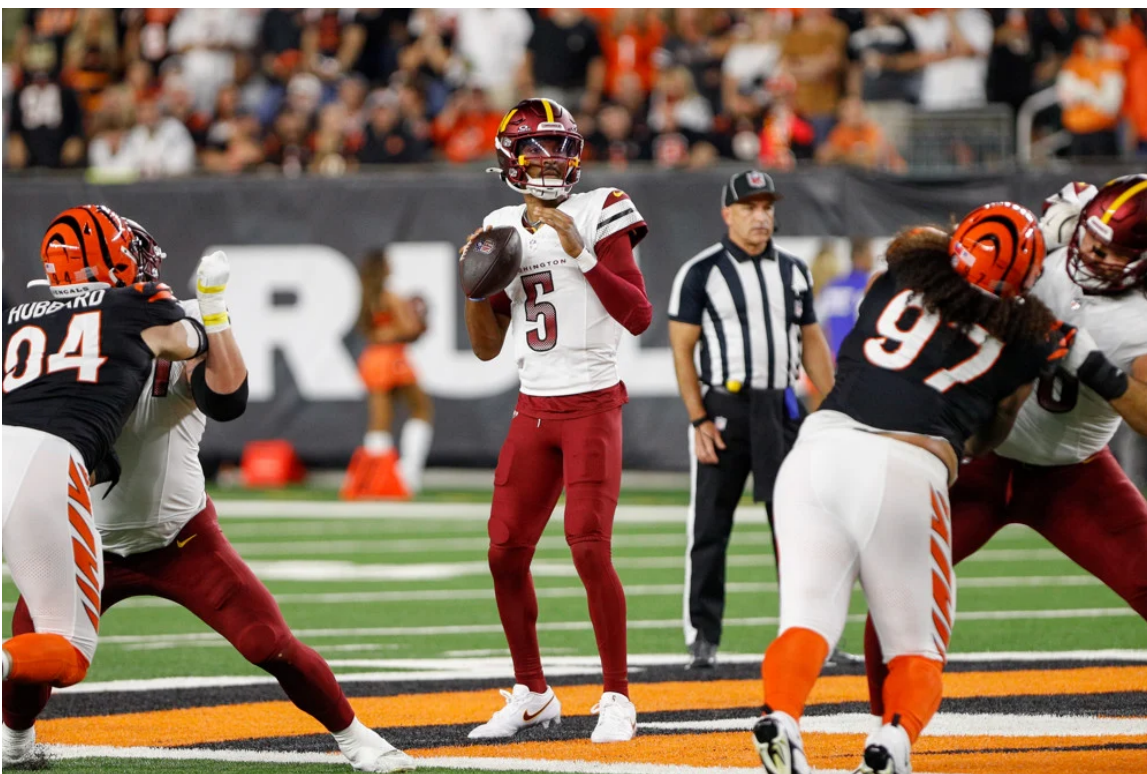


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GPP Leverage: Week 1

SAM BROTT // SEP 11, 2026



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NFL DFS is back! After months of debating depth charts, projecting workloads, and talking ourselves into our favorite players, we finally get a full Sunday slate to put those opinions to the test. I'm sure we'll all feel great about them right up until the first round of goal-line carries.

Welcome to the first *NFL GPP Leverage* column of the 2026 season. I'm excited to be back for my third year writing this article and talking through one of my favorite parts of tournament DFS: how to build lineups that offer leverage against our opponents.

For those who are new to *Leverage*, the goal of this column is to help us think through the slate. Each week, we'll look at the slate primarily from a macro perspective before providing some micro examples. The individual players make the macro ideas concrete, but understanding the reasoning should help us find additional ways to apply them in our lineups.

I've shared this quote from my *Leverage*-writing predecessor Drew Dinkmeyer in each of my first two seasons writing this column, and I'm going to share it again because it captures exactly what I want readers to take away from each article:

"The examples I highlight will be in my portfolio of lineups, but if you want to improve considerably as a GPP player, mastering the concepts is more important than copying the answers."

That becomes especially relevant between Friday afternoon and Sunday kickoff. A player who looks like a great leverage option when this article is published can become one of the slate's most popular plays by kickoff. When that happens, we should revisit what made the play appealing and whether the new ownership changes our decision. Ideally, the discussion

here gives us a useful starting point for making those adjustments as news, projections, and market sentiment evolve throughout the weekend.

With those shifting slate dynamics in mind, I plan to change the structure of *Leverage* slightly this season. I'll organize the discussion around how I see the slate playing out as a whole, using individual players and expected chalk to illustrate those ideas. This should help make the column more useful and relevant throughout the weekend. It should also allow me the capacity to include a data analysis project each week — if you ever have an analysis idea you'd like to see included, don't hesitate to reach out!

I also want to preface that my own perspective comes primarily from playing small-field tournaments on DraftKings, but my goal is for the macro ideas discussed here to be useful across DFS platforms and contest sizes. For those particularly interested in FanDuel, we have revamped our coverage for FanDuel NFL this season, and that will include new written coverage released on Saturdays in addition to the FanDuel Examination show on Sunday mornings hosted by Andrew Wiggins.

Alright, with all of the intros out of the way, let's get into the slate.

Week 1 gives us plenty to work with from a leverage standpoint because even our strongest expectations come with unanswered questions. We can have good reasons to expect an offense to improve or a defense to remain strong and still see something different on Sunday. The challenge is deciding which alternatives are plausible enough, and rewarding enough, to build around. We don't need every popular assumption to be wrong. A lineup can benefit quite a bit from getting one meaningful disagreement right, especially when the rest of its pieces fit that outcome.

In fact, our fantasy-point projections at ETR have historically been roughly as accurate in Week 1 as in all other weeks of the season, as shown in the

table below. This demonstrates that, although the field will tend to IKB (the Adam Levitan-popularized acronym for “I know better [than the projections]”) more in Week 1, we actually don’t need to get as far off the board from projections as we might instinctively think.

ETR Projections Accuracy: Week 1 vs. Weeks 2–17

2022–2025 NFL Seasons | DraftKings Slates with 8+ Games

Projection measure	Week 1 difference
Average fantasy-point miss	7.1% smaller
Point error (extra weight on large misses)	11.5% smaller
Ranking accuracy within each position	0.033 lower correlation
Average actual scoring vs. projected scoring	0.80 DK points lower
Average target-share miss	-0.01 percentage points
Frequency of target-share misses ≥ 10 percentage points	-1.2 percentage points
Average miss in share of team RB carries	+0.70 percentage points
Frequency of RB carry-share misses ≥ 10 percentage points	+3.0 percentage points

While it’s reassuring that our projections have historically held up just as well in Week 1, we certainly will get some spots wrong. And if we can predict or take shots on which spots those might be, we can gain considerable leverage by having our lineups play into assumptions that disagree with the market. Let’s walk through a selection of games on Sunday’s main slate and briefly consider how we can gain leverage by going against the most common assumptions in the market.

Jets at Titans

The market assumes both teams will struggle significantly on offense, and I expect limited ownership across both offenses. But what if **Cam Ward** and the Titans take a big leap on offense this season despite their struggles in the preseason? What if **Geno Smith** is a significant upgrade over the lackluster QB play they had last season, and he can support the plethora of

weapons they have at the skill positions? It is not out of the realm of possibility that the Jets turn into one of the more fun offenses in the league this season.

Bears at Panthers

The market assumes Chicago's offense will take a significant leap in its second season under **Ben Johnson**, with a poor defense creating even more opportunities for high-scoring games. But what if that offensive leap doesn't happen, or at least takes longer than expected? Down the stretch of 2025, the Bears often struggled to generate significant offense until the fourth quarter. Their late-game success gives us reasons for optimism, but we still need to see whether they can produce consistently throughout games. If those earlier struggles carry into this season, we could be getting ahead of ourselves by treating Chicago as one of the league's best offenses before it has demonstrated that consistency.

Buccaneers at Bengals

The market assumes Cincinnati will continue to be a team we can count on for shootouts: an excellent offense paired with a defense that struggles to get stops. But what if the Bengals' defensive improvement down the stretch of 2025 was the beginning of something sustainable? That unit played considerably better after its bye, and they added **Dexter Lawrence** in the offseason. **Joe Burrow** has even discussed the possibility that a better overall team won't need him to throw as much. If the defense has become more reliable, we may need to reconsider both how aggressively we attack Cincinnati with opposing offenses and how much passing volume we expect from the Bengals themselves.



Saints at Lions

The market assumes Detroit will pick up where it left off offensively, and this is shaping up to be the most popular game on the slate. We have plenty of evidence that the Lions can score, including their success with **Dan Campbell** calling plays late last season. But what if the transition to **Drew Petzing** introduces more uncertainty than we're accounting for? Detroit has a new play-caller, and the offense could regress to the struggles we saw before Campbell assumed play-calling in 2025. The personnel can remain excellent while the timing and execution take a step back. We may be treating the Lions' offensive efficiency as a constant when some of the conditions that produced it have changed.

Bills at Texans

The market assumes Houston's defense will again make life difficult for Buffalo, and there is very little interest in the Bills' passing game. But what if the addition of **D.J. Moore** changes how effectively the entire offense functions against even a top defense? Moore gives Buffalo the best receiver they've had since **Stefon Diggs**, potentially changing how defenses allocate coverage against the Bills and creating more space for everyone else. Even if Houston's defense is excellent, as the market anticipates, Buffalo's improved passing game could succeed even against the defenses we would normally prefer to avoid.

Browns at Jaguars

The market assumes Cleveland will once again have one of the offenses we want to avoid, with Jacksonville's defense attracting plenty of interest. But what if **Todd Monken** can make the Browns a functional offense sooner than expected? The quarterback concerns are real, but what if Monken can reduce how often this offense needs its quarterback to overcome difficult situations? Easier throws and fewer obvious passing downs could make



Cleveland more efficient without requiring exceptional quarterback play. An improvement in those areas could benefit the entire unit without requiring **Deshaun Watson** to rediscover his best form. We don't need Cleveland to become one of the league's best offenses for the field to be overly confident that it will remain one of the worst.

Falcons at Steelers

The market assumes Pittsburgh will remain a fairly limited offense, and Atlanta's quarterback uncertainty makes it easy to dismiss this game as a whole. But what if the reunion of **Aaron Rodgers** and **Mike McCarthy** produces a more efficient Steelers offense than we're used to seeing? Rodgers has discussed playing more under center and using more play-action and movement to improve early-down efficiency. His familiarity with McCarthy's system could help those changes translate more quickly than they would for a quarterback learning everything from scratch. If Pittsburgh can consistently create manageable situations and sustain drives, its reputation as an unappealing offense could leave the field slow to recognize a better Steelers offense.

Cardinals at Chargers

The market assumes **Mike McDaniels** will unlock an excellent Chargers offense while L.A.'s defense remains a difficult matchup for opponents. Most of the enthusiasm for this game is on the Los Angeles side. But what if the coaching change on defense matters just as much as the one on offense? **Jesse Minter** has left for Baltimore, and **Chris O'Leary** is taking over after spending last season coordinating Western Michigan's defense. If the Chargers take a step back defensively, we may be too quick to dismiss Arizona's offense based on the matchup, especially after the offensive explosions we saw from the Cardinals last season when trailing. McDaniels' success could make Chargers games even more appealing if both offenses

can sustain drives.

Dolphins at Raiders

The market assumes Miami will be terrible on both offense and defense, making the Dolphins an easy team to attack and a difficult one to trust. But what if the offense is more functional than the overall assessment suggests? **Bobby Slowik** and the Dolphins have an opportunity to build around **Malik Willis'** mobility, forcing defenses to account for the quarterback as a runner and potentially creating more room for the running backs and easier throws off play-action. Miami's defense could be every bit as bad as expected while the offense proves capable of sustaining drives and contributing to high-scoring games. We should consider whether the expectation of a bad team is making us too dismissive of what this particular offensive system might do well.

Commanders at Eagles

The market assumes Washington will struggle offensively in Philadelphia, especially after the loss of OT **Laremy Tunsil**, and the lack of interest suggests the field is comfortable waiting to see improvement before buying back in. But what if the Commanders' injury-disrupted 2025 season is giving us the wrong starting point? A healthy **Jayden Daniels** gives the offense a chance to regain the efficiency and explosiveness it showed in 2024 — and remember: Daniels and **Terry McLaurin** arguably didn't play a single game together in 2025 where both were at full strength. Philadelphia is a difficult opening test, but we should consider whether that matchup is making us too quick to overlook a potentially stronger version of the Commanders.

Finally, I want to consider how efficient market ownership has historically been in the opening weeks of NFL seasons. To be completely transparent, I started down the path of comparing historical ownership efficiencies between Week 1 and other weeks with the plan to demonstrate my hypothesis that market ownerships have signaled extreme overconfidence in how NFL teams will operate at the start of a new season. But that wasn't the full story, and the field deserves some credit here.

For the analysis shown in the tables below, I matched pairs of players at the same position whose salaries were within \$500 and whose final ETR projections were within one fantasy point. One player had to carry at least twice the actual ownership of the other, with a minimum gap of five percentage points to qualify. I limited the sample to regular-season Weeks 1–17 and slates with at least eight games, then compared each group's average ownership and frequency of scoring at least 25 DraftKings points. This gives us a way to examine how much additional upside the field's preferred players delivered relative to similarly priced and projected alternatives, and whether that trade-off differed between Week 1 and the rest of the season. Of course, reaching 25 DK points is just one measure of upside, and it doesn't capture everything that determines a player's tournament value.



Milly Maker Contests | 2022–2025 NFL Seasons

Player in pair	Week 1		Weeks 2–17	
	Average ownership	Scored 25+ DK points	Average ownership	Scored 25+ DK points
Higher-owned	12.0%	9.3%	13.6%	12.3%
Lower-owned	3.9%	3.1%	3.8%	10.4%

\$100 Single Entry Spy Contests | 2023–2025 NFL Seasons

Player in pair	Week 1		Weeks 2–17	
	Average ownership	Scored 25+ DK points	Average ownership	Scored 25+ DK points
Higher-owned	14.5%	7.0%	14.9%	13.4%
Lower-owned	3.6%	4.3%	3.4%	11.4%

Even when choosing between players with similar salaries and ETR projections, the more popular player generally performed better. In Week 1, the higher-owned player outscored his counterpart approximately 60% of the time in the Milly Maker and 54% in The Spy. The more popular players also reached 25 DK points more frequently. There is useful information in ownership, and we should consider why the field prefers one player before automatically gravitating toward the other.

But the size of that preference matters. In Week 1 Spy contests, the lower-owned players carried about one-quarter of the ownership while reaching 25 DK points roughly 60% as often. That is an interesting trade-off when we're choosing between otherwise comparable options. The Milly Maker results were less appealing, as the lower-owned players carried about one-third of the ownership and reached 25 points about one-third as often. Later in the season, the ceiling gap narrowed considerably in both contests while the ownership gap remained substantial.

The ownership premium was generally better supported by these results in Week 1 than later in the season, which gives us a reason to respect the field's preferences even with all of the unanswered questions. But there is still room to consider whether a popular assumption is carrying too much weight in our opponents' lineups. For the games discussed above, we can

use our projections to help identify alternatives that remain competitive without requiring everything to break their way. When those alternatives also offer a substantial ownership discount, we don't need to believe they are the most likely outcome to have interest in building around them.

As is always the case with NFL data, I want to caution that we're dealing with very small sample sizes here, particularly when it comes to the number of years of Week 1 data. It is certainly possible that over time we would see the Week 1 rates regress toward those of Weeks 2-17.

Putting it all together, I don't see a compelling reason to stray further from projections or chase lower ownership simply because it's Week 1 — even though I came into this analysis expecting to find one. Yet we should still recognize that at least a few teams will shock us with their performances every season. And if we can find those surprises at low ownership in Week 1, we can gain significant positive leverage against our opponents.

Alright, that'll do it for Week 1 *Leverage*. I'm hosting a Q&A in Discord every Sunday at 9:00 a.m. ET. Feel free to drop me any questions you have about the slate in the “nfl-dfs-ama” channel, and I'll do my best to answer them on Sunday.

Best of luck to all of you on Sunday, and make sure to tune in to all of **our live shows** throughout the weekend!

Jayden Daniels, Washington Commanders, Dinkmeyer's Leverage, In-Season Package





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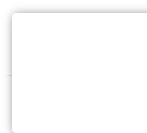
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